slightest intention to loosen the foundation under the feet of those among you who have made peace with their conscience and have gained that firm foothold which is a prime requisite of one's conduct in life. To do so would be a reprehensible undertaking, unfair both to those who feel so secure in their religious faith that they do not permit a natural-scientific knowledge to influence it in any manner whatever, as well as to those who feel no need for any particular religious activity and are fully contented with an intuitive ethics. But these latter are likely to represent a small minority only. For the history of all eras and races teaches us only all too impressively that the candid faith which nothing can confuse, such as that which religion instills in its followers who are busy in active life, is the very fountainhead of the mightiest incentives to significant creative achievements, in the field of politics no less than in the realms of art and science.

This candid faith—and let us not delude ourselves about this—no longer exists today, even among the great masses of the nation, nor can it be revived any longer by considerations and measures oriented toward the past. For "to believe" means "to recognize as a truth," and the knowledge of nature, continually advancing on incontestably safe tracks, has made it utterly impossible for a person possessing some training in natural science to recognize as founded on truth the many reports of extraordinary occurrences contradicting the laws of nature, of miracles which are still commonly regarded as essential supports and confirmations of religious doctrines, and which formerly used to be accepted as facts pure and simple, without doubt or criticism.

Therefore, he who is in earnest about his faith and cannot bear to see it conflict with his scientific learning, must decide in his conscience whether in all honesty, he may still consider himself a member of a religious community whose creed incorporates a belief in miracles.

For a while many could still find a certain temporary reassurance by trying to steer a middle course and limiting themselves to accepting as true a few miracles of especial importance. But such an attitude is untenable in the long run. The faith in miracles must yield ground, step by step, before the steady and firm advance of the forces of science, and its total defeat is indubitably a mere matter of time. The young generation of our own era, which in any case is sharply critical, toward traditional views, no longer permits itself to be bound innerly by doctrines which it regards as contradictory to the laws of nature. And the spiritually most gifted members of the young generation in particular, those destined to be the future leaders of their nation and who not seldom harbour a burning desire for religious satisfaction, are the ones most painfully hit by such incongruities. They are the ones who must suffer most heavily if they are sincere in seeking a compromise between their religious and their scientific beliefs.